Spotlight: News On Air

Discussion: Swachh Bharat to Swachhata as a Jan Andolan | Program Transcript

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Chapter 1: Introduction to the Mission

Akashvani: This is Akashvani. In the program Spotlight, now we bring you a discussion on Swachh Bharat to Swachhata as a Jan Andolan. The participants are Akshay Rao, former Director General Swachh Bharat Mission, and Shreya Pathak, anchor. October 2nd is a **significant** day for India's journey towards cleanliness. It marks the birth **anniversary** of Mahatma Gandhi and also the **anniversary** of the launch of the Swachh Bharat Mission in 2014. Over the past 12 years, the **campaign** has moved beyond cleanliness drives to become a wider public movement with citizens, institutions, and governments playing a role.

This year, October 2 also marks the beginning of the **implementation** phase of special campaign 6.0, which focuses on **institutionalizing** cleanliness, reducing pendency, and **promoting** **scientific** e-waste **management** across government offices. To understand this journey, we are joined by Akshay Rao. Welcome sir.

Chapter 2: The Four Pillars of Success

Shreya Pathak: Sir, starting with my first question, let us begin with a larger journey 12 years after the launch. How do you look at its **transformation** from a government program into a people's movement?

Akshay Rao: The idea came to the Prime Minister who announced it 12 years back, and in his mind, it was very clear that it is going to be a people's program. The word "Jan Andolan" has been used in this context. There are four pillars, Shreya. First 'P' is political leadership, which the Prime Minister provided **abundantly** and **passionately**, and **prodded** all the other leaders to also lead the program.

Second 'P' is public finance. Never in the history of independent India so much money was put into sanitation. Sanitation was a poor **recipient** of funds. We had a well-funded mission running in phase one, now in phase two, and perhaps phase three is going to be **conceived** very soon.

Third 'P' is **partnership** because it was recognized that this cannot be done by one government department. All the ministries, all agencies outside the government, the **corporate** world, media, and international agencies, all were built into a partnership and it was a work together.

Akshay Rao (Cont'd): The last 'P' is people's participation. The program was taken over by the people themselves. Six and a half lakh **rural** villages, 4,800 towns, two and a half lakh panchayats all were **ignited** by the flame of Swachhata. In the first phase (2014-2019), it was not just creating this **infrastructure** but also to engineer a **massive** behavior change.

The second phase, which is now moving towards a close, is a little more **complex**. The task is waste management and has shifted from villages to towns because we have huge amounts of solid waste across towns. As India is **aspiring** to be Viksit Bharat by 2047, we must have clean and **sustainable** towns where the economy can actually take place.

Chapter 3: Lessons in Behavioral Change

Shreya Pathak: Sir, that was very **insightful**. Behavioral change is often much harder than building infrastructure. What have been the biggest lessons from Swachh Bharat Mission in changing everyday habits and making cleanliness a sustained behavior?

Akshay Rao: I mentioned the four Ps. Let me also tell about the four Ss. First 'S' was **scale**. In 2014, India had 60 crores of people **defecating** in the open. We had a massive scale to cover. Second is sunset clause; very intelligently, 2019 was put as the target date for making the country open defecation free.

Third 'S' was **stigma**. Toilets, sanitation, and sanitary napkins were things families believed could not be talked about openly. When the Prime Minister talked about toilets in his speech in August 2014, it **resonated** with our women in the **hinterland**. We took to emptying twin pit toilets and cleaned up the dirt that had **accumulated** over time to tell the world that it becomes good fertilizer. Emptying the pit was a way to remove the stigma.

Fourth 'S' is **sustainability**. Even if we achieved ODF years back, there could be cracks. It has to be **ingrained** in the family, the colony, and the state, otherwise, we can have a **relapse** of bad behavior. It always requires a community effort. For example, in a city like Indore, they never move into anything which can be called the **antithesis** of Swachhata. They **segregate** their garbage and process it properly. Other cities are catching up, but we have miles to go to achieve **comprehensive** cleanliness.

Chapter 4: Citizen Responsibility

Shreya Pathak: So true sir. We have seen Swachh increasingly being linked with environmental sustainability, from waste segregation to reducing plastic. How do you think cleanliness moved from being primarily a government responsibility to something citizens see as their own responsibility?

Akshay Rao: If you recall, Mahatma Gandhi said unless you wield the broom yourself, you can't see the world clean. It has to be people doing cleanliness themselves in the house. A child must know from the beginning how to keep their room and surroundings clean. They must not allow garbage to be heaped around. We should not sort of leave things to a sanitation worker to come and do everything.

The country knows there has to be basic segregation like organic and inorganic waste, blue and green bins. Even that minimum habit has not **percolated** to every member everywhere, though present rules are pushing for it. In cities like Indore, people are practicing up to six bins. Waste when segregated is wealth; when not segregated, it's dirt and disease.

Chapter 5: Future Priorities and Closing

Shreya Pathak: Moving on to my last question. As we look towards the next phase, what should be the priorities now and how can India ensure that Swachhata remains a daily habit?

Akshay Rao: It cannot be **confined** **symbolically** to a day, a week, or a month. It must **permeate** into life in the families, the community, the village, and the city. We cannot remain satisfied with open defecation-free villages; we must clear the waste around us, learn to create less waste, and scientifically dispose of it. Swachhata is social and cultural in nature. It has to be deeply **embedded**, triggered, and educated.

Shreya Pathak: Over the years, Swachh Bharat Mission has involved local communities, transforming from cleanliness drives to a mission that has kept Jan Andolan alive. Thank you Akshay Rao sir for discussing your insightful thoughts.

Akshay Rao: Thank you very much.

Akashvani: You were listening to a discussion on Swachh Bharat to Swachhata as a Jan Andolan. The participants were Akshay Rao, former Director General Swachh Bharat Mission, and Shreya Pathak, anchor. This program was produced and presented by the News Services Division of Akashvani. You can listen to it on our mobile app News On AIR. This program is also available on our YouTube Channel.

Vocabulary Guide Available

A fully alphabetized vocabulary table detailing all the highlighted CEFR B1, B2, C1, and C2 words—including English meanings, Hindi translations, and example sentences—is provided in the accompanying Vocabulary Document.